



**Mother and baby homes (including
pre-1948 Workhouses) and
Magdalene laundries oral history
project**

Interview with DH

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Interviewer: Oliva Dee

Transcriber: Oliva Dee

Interview conducted online

DH explains that his birth mother was in a Good Shepherd mother and baby home in Northern Ireland, prior to his birth, in the late 1960s. DH was adopted. He narrates an account of the long process of re-uniting with his birth mother and meeting members of his family, which occurred when he was in his thirties. He describes how he came to decide to look for his birth mother and the assistance he received from those holding the records of his adoption, which he describes as being largely positive. DH describes the process of liaising with the social worker who helped him access his adoption records to confirm the identity of his birth mother. This social worker could then formally write to his birth mother to say that DH wanted to make contact with her. After contact was made, there was a long period (six years in total) before a meeting was agreed by his birth mother. DH describes the various bumps in the road that he encountered in building a relationship with his birth mother. The couple that adopted DH also adopted another baby boy [three years before DH] and a baby girl [two years after DH] whose mothers had been in the same Good Shepherd mother and baby institution as DH's birth mother. DH narrates that his adoptive mother's family connections with a priest and a nun and assisted with her plans to adopt.

To ensure anonymity names and dates and other potentially identifying details are redacted. This includes the name of the Good Shepherd mother and baby

home in which DH's mother spent the weeks before his birth. Redactions are indicated by **.

OD: Ok, so just for the tape, it's the 6th of July 2021 and this is for the mother and baby home and Magdalene laundry project in Northern Ireland. My name is Olivia Dee, and I'm just here on Zoom with an interviewee who is going to tell me about his experience. I just want to say that you'll obviously will have heard [here the interviewer is referring to the Zoom alert that indicated that the meeting is being recorded] that so if it stops, at any point, you'll hear that the recording has stopped. Just ask me anytime you want to stop. If there's anything you don't want to talk about just say 'no' and I'll change direction and we won't talk about it anymore. No ... don't worry about...

DH: OK.

OD: ...offence or anything, it's completely up to you. OK. So, we have actually spoken before a bit about this ... before we knew whether or not [we would get the go ahead to do an interview] we, sort of, had, had talked a little bit before. But I'm just wondering if, for the purposes of the tape, you can tell me a little bit about your connection to these homes or the laundries and what it is that your experience has been.

DH: Yeah. Hi, my name is *redacted*. I was born on the *date in the late 1960s* in *name of hospital*. I ... my mother, my mother had been entered *name of a Good Shepherd mother and baby home* *date prior to DH's birth*. Subsequently, I was adopted from *the same Good Shepherd mother and baby home*. I believe it was *date redacted*. So, my period of actually residing,

outside the womb, in *the Good Shepherd mother and baby home* between *redacted* and *redacted* [a period of roughly two months].

OD: Ok. So obviously you have very clear idea of your dates there. Did you always have those, or have you recently found out that, kind of, part of your history?

DH: Yeah, no I didn't. I ... knew my birth date. My adoption date I didn't know until I was able to get some records from the *adoption agency*, on ... it's basically a photocopy of the, the admittance ledger of *the Good Shepherd mother and baby home*, which has my birth mother's details and the date she entered and then the date she left. So, until I received that, I didn't have any other information.

OD: And how, how old were you when you managed to get hold of that information?

DH: I was probably in my early thirties...

OD: Oh wow!

DH: ...when I started looking for it and talking with *adoption agency* and actually starting the search for my birth mother was when I was able to get that level of information. Growing up I always knew I was adopted and I did have ... the only information I had for my birth mother, or about my birth mother was a name and an address. And that was all, I didn't have an age, didn't have any information about the time she spent in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* or anything like that.

OD: Ok. It's really ... it's really interesting because people have very different experiences of trying to get this information. So, some people spend a very long time and they're not able to get anything, some people are kept in the loop kind of, their entire lives and have a much better sense of it. Do you ... from your, kind of, adopted family and your adoptive mother and father, do they have much information about your birth mother other than the information that you mentioned here?

DH: No. No, they didn't.

OD: So, they had come to *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home* to adopt without any knowledge of where ... Okay.

DH: Yeah. So, there ... I have subsequently, I was able to find in my own family's records or, sorry, my own family's documents, letters that have been sent from the nuns in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*, to my mother. Just basically saying we've got a ... we hear you're interested in adopting another boy, we have a baby, you know, and that was it, and then ... I think that was dated probably *date redacted*. I think sometime around that, so I would have been like two weeks old. So ... no, no, no significant information exchanged. At the time of adoption, there was no ... I, I know there was a social worker from *name of town redacted* went down to *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* to meet my mother but that was ... that's all and I only know that because there was a letter from social services to *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* from that social worker to say that they would be down to meet ... So that was at the ... probably *date redacted* sometime in *date redacted* probably, to ... As soon as they did ... the whole adoption process had started.

OD: Ok. So ... so that information is fairly limited based on what you've been given, so I'm wondering what, what, what stopped you ... or what ... rather what, what encouraged you at thirty ... or in your thirties, to start looking? Had you started looking before then, or at any point? Or was that when you felt able to or ... what ...

DH: Yeah, that was when I felt able too. I think when I was younger in my late teens it was always something that was there. Certainly, all the way through my twenties, it was always something that was there and it wasn't until I had had a conversation with a friend one time and he advised me, you know, if I'm gonna do this it's going to be hard and, you know, you really need some sort of support system and someone to fall back on in your life. And maybe a year or two after that I had been in *overseas location* with work and I had met my wife, and then when I came back to *location in Ireland* I decided then that I wanted to start it. So that was in *date redacted*, so really the information that I got from *adoption agency* was, kind of, drip-fed over that period and it wasn't until maybe *date redacted*, until I actually met my birth mother, that I got a copy of those records. So, all ... a lot of the information on the records had been given to me over the phone, you know, but limited, as I said I was, kind of, drip-fed from the *adoption agency*.

OD: Right. What was your experience with the *adoption agency*?

DH: Mine was very good and I don't know if that was ... I don't know if it was based on my expectations of what I was going to get. Initially, when I contacted them, they said it would be eighteen to ... eighteen months to two years before they could actually take on the case because they were just so overwhelmed, but what they did do was they said we can help guide you and give you directions on how to do it. Which for me was way more interesting that way anyway

because it was my search, you know, and it became much more personal ... satisfying to do it that way. So, in terms of that I always found the person I was working with, *name redacted*, I always found she was incredibly supportive, incredibly helpful and I personally had a wonderful experience. Now I don't know what else I don't know, in terms of what other records exist and everything else. So, I know I was given a photocopy of ... a one page photocopy and that was the summation of the information that was given to me. So if there's anything else I don't know, but personally speaking my ... I found *name redacted* incredibly supportive and incredibly helpful.

OD: That's really good to hear.

DH: Yeah.

OD: I think it, it's, it's really heart breaking when people have had a bad experience. Not necessarily *name of adoption agency* or anything like that, just in general ... trying to...

DH: Yeah. And I know when I'm on the Zoom calls and, and I hear people, you know, talking about *name redacted*, specifically in a negative way, I feel so sorry because, you know, ... I feel so sorry for them, and feel so sorry that *name redacted* had maybe got that perception because there was a period in my life ... I, you know, around about that time ... where, you know, she was the most important person, other than my wife, in my life and I just thought she was fantastic. So, no ... I've no ... if I met her today I'd give her a big, big hug.

OD: That's really lovely. And I always think it must ... it must just, you know, ... the web to un ... you have to, kind of, weave to find these things, is so difficult, especially based on the records ... Some of the records that we've seen

are, you know, in books, tucked away in cupboards somewhere, you know, ... it's about ... we're not dealing necessarily with like, digitised records that we think we're dealing with, it's so much else. So, we don't have to say where you are but you moved out of Ireland, out of Northern Ireland.

DH: Yeah.

OD: When you were adopted did you go into Northern Ireland or into the Republic?

DH: I stayed. I didn't cross jurisdictions. I stayed ... so I moved from ... my adopted family were in *town in NI* and I grew up [there], and then later in life I moved about quite a bit between England, *a location in Republic of Ireland*, *a location in NI* and then moved abroad to *redacted* in around about 1999, 2000, two thousand ...

OD: Yeah ... Sorry I didn't ... it doesn't need to be too personal, I was just curious about whether or not you had, kind of, you know, if that the family had moved you to *redacted* or if not ...

DB: No, no, no, no that's a personal decision.

OD: Ok, fantastic. Can we talk a bit about the process for you emotionally, psychologically? What was it like to try and find ... what, kind of, methods did you use? Obviously worked with *adoption agency* but you said you it was sort of, self-guided as well ...

DB: Yeah. So, initially it was basically, you know, she [referring to the social worker at the adoption agency] was like: "you need to find her birth certificate,

you need to try and find marriage certificates, need to try and find this.” So, I went into the records office in Belfast one time that I was home on holiday and did a search, found her birth certificate and from there I think I found her parent’s marriage certificate [referring to his birth mother]. And then ... that was, that was Public Records Office that I used and then online I think after that I was able to find her marriage certificate and from there, there was a couple of other things like census records, and things like that, that I was able to give this package of material to *adoption agency* and say “I found her, it’s why I think it’s her.” And then when *adoption agency social worker* reviewed that she was like, “I agree, I think you're right” and then she had sent the letter [to DB’s birth mother]. So yeah it was pretty, it was pretty emotional but it was, it was ... at that point, that point of the journey ... it was very exciting, you know, I was, was really engaged in it and everything else so it was ... it was something that was unique to me, I have never done anything like this before obviously so ... no it was good, that was an interesting experience.

OD: But had you ... obviously you didn't know any of the circumstances around that?

DH: No.

OD: Was that quite ... was that quite scary to, to know that you would find those out because I, I, I'm trying to think sort of, think about how ...

DH: Yeah it was, it was scary, it was, you know, try to think of how I can compare it to anything or ... it was really a step into the unknown, you know? I didn't know what it was going to find out. I didn't know if she was alive or dead. I didn't know the circumstances of my conception. I didn't know anything of that so, you know, it was very much ... I knew that there could ... there, maybe

an outcome that was gonna be emotionally damaging and hurtful. But at the same time, I was betting on that it would be the opposite and, you know, really driven to, to that goal. So, I was prepared to take the risk for the reward.

OD: Yeah. And you're so interesting because obviously you're coming at this from completely the opposite perspective. So many of the women that we've spoken to said that if they've chosen not to reunite or find their children, they've said sometimes it's because they want them to have had a happy life and they don't want to interrupt it or anything like that, or they say, you know, 'I'm worried that they'll hate me or they'll be guilty, they'll think that I did the wrong thing or ...', you know, all of these components that that are so heart breaking to hear from that side ... But I suppose it ... did you have any of those feelings? Was that something that you had considered?

DH: I didn't, I certainly didn't have any negative feelings at all because, you know, and ... I think I, you know, I waited until the right time in my life, until I was, you know, mature enough to be able to handle it. I don't think if I had've done in my twenties I'd have done it in the same manner and I would've been a little haphazard and I don't think it would have been ... it would have turned out as well as it did. But, no, I didn't have any feelings in of hurt ... in terms of that ... I didn't, you know, there was always ... there was always abandonment feelings and things that growing up that were, you know, subconscious but I didn't have any animosity towards her at all.

OD: That's so ... it's so hard ... it's just so interesting to hear it from that opposite perspective because

DH: Yeah.

OD: the ...you know, whenever anyone says that my, my gut instinct is to say “of course no one feels that way!” but, you know, I can't answer that! And your feelings are completely valid too and it's, it's so it's so heartbreaking to hear from both perspectives, sometimes, how people feel towards these meetings. When you had found your, your information and you'd gone to *adoption agency* with ... with, sort of, the information ... is that what you were encouraged to do rather than contacting her [birth mother] yourself directly?

DH: Yes!

OD: OK.

DH: Yes. No. *adoption agency* was like, you know, “be careful ... you better not do this on your own because it's not going to turnout well.” So, I had full trust in *name redacted* and was leaning on her experience and expertise, so I was 100% to follow her direction and there was never the temptation to do it in any other way. I knew I had the information and that I knew that it was kinda dangerous. It was a little but like, you know, Frodo¹ having the ring in his pocket, that it was, you know, it was powerful but at the same time is quite dangerous. So, I, I was like okay, here you take it from here now *adoption agency*. Now if things, if things had've went different then there's, there's, there was always the alternative to go to a Plan B. Now what that Plan B would've looked like, I, I ... at that point I'd never really thought about it. There was a Plan B that popped in the head later in the process because things didn't go as expected initially. So, at that point, then, it was like okay now what? So ...

¹ A reference to the fictional character in J.R. Tolkien's, *The Lord of the Rings*.

OD: And, again, I don't, I don't want to ask you anything too personal so just, just tell me what you're comfortable with, but what was the, the first, kind of, response that you had got from your birth mother? Was it ... did you get a letter or was it a phone call or did you meet in person or ...

DH: Yes, so the whole process was quite long. So that was probably about *date redacted* whenever *adoption agency* got all the information or, or late *year redacted* I can't really recall. I'm going to say *date redacted.*
Adoption agency social worker sent a letter and didn't get a response and then sent another letter, I think to say I'm going to call and she had talked me through the whole process and everything else and was like "this is typically how it works and this is typically, you know, if they've kept you quiet and not talked about you then usually a phone call jolts them into action, so to speak." So, at that point then *birth mother's name redacted* had made contact with *adoption agency social worker* and it was very much: "I'll meet [DH] if he needs it but I'm really not ... I don't need it for me and, you know, it's not something that I really want to do, but for him, you know, I'll do it." And I think it all became ... it all became clear afterwards what that was all about but at the time it was, it was hard because for me, you know, if the two of us weren't invested in it then there was no point. Her partner at the time then reached out to *adoption agency* and said "I'll meet [DH]" and I was thinking, well you're not my father, I don't know you, I'm not looking for you, I'm looking for my birth mother so not really interested in you. So, at that point the whole process fizzled out. And then, you know, *the adoption agency* was like "OK well, you know, what? This isn't going go anywhere. If she's not invested in the same way as you it's not going to work out." And I realised that as well, so I ... again putting my trust in *adoption agency* expertise and experience. I was like "Yeah, no, I agree." So then maybe about a year later, I had asked *adoption agency social worker* if she wouldn't mind reaching out again, and at that point I think that

was *date redacted* and at that point [my birth mother's] partner had just passed away a couple of months previously. So [i] was like: "I can't deal with this at all. I'm not, not ... no way." So *adoption agency social worker* was like: "Listen we can't keep badgering this woman." And I said: "Yeah I know what you mean but please let her know that my door's always open and that if she ever changes her mind, I'm always receptive to an approach from her." And that's, that's the way we left it at that point. So, everything was shutdown. I kinda ... was incredibly disappointed, incredibly hurt I think. I think that ... that, that's ... at that point that was the lowest I've been because to be rejected twice as an adult was really, really hard, you know. Your abandonment, or what you feel is abandoned or being given up as a child, there's subconscious hurt there, but this, this was really raw. And I don't think I could have went through any of that if it wasn't for my wife and the support that, that she gave me so.

OD: Lovely.

DH: So, that was, that was, that was a hard time and then jumping on a bit. I would say about *date redacted* ... Now in my mindset, I'd actually went back and looked at some emails around about that time so it's pretty fresh, my mindset at the time because I was having a discussion with my older brother, was that I'm gonna look for my birth father and I'm gonna look for my ... I'm gonna try and contact my half-brother and half-sister because *adoption agency* had given me that information that I had a half-brother and a half-sister. So I was like, well if they don't know about me that's not fair on them and it's also not fair on me. So *birth mother's name redacted* doesn't want to meet, that's her business but there's no way that she can stop us from having a relationship. So that was really my frame of mind around about *date redacted* and then I was home from *overseas location* on holidays one day or one time and there was a letter from *adoption agency*, saying '...hope you're being

well. We've had some contact, can you get ... can you get in contact with us, we've had some development.' So, at that point I kinda thought 'woah, something's happened' so then I reached out to *adoption agency* [and they explained] '*birth mother's name redacted*' has got back to us and she's interested in meeting.'

OD: [referring to name of DH's birth mother] And this is your birth mother ... is ...?

DH: Yeah, yeah.

OD: That's such a long time period to have gone up and down like that [the reconnection process took 6 years from start to finish].

DH: Yeah.

OD: I can't even imagine how.

DH: Yeah. It was quite hard. It was quite hard. So, then the process started with ... letter writing through *adoption agency*. So *birth mother's name redacted* would send a letter to *adoption agency* and [they] would vet it and then send it to me and then I would do the same. And then it got to a point where she was comfortable with us. There was actually, there was actually a postal strike in Northern Ireland, so the letters were getting really delayed, so *adoption agency* was like "listen... youse two just send letters directly to each other." So that that's what we started doing. And then I think around ... it was either *dates redacted* that we had set up a conference call. So *name of DH's birth mother redacted*, myself and *social worker*, we just had a little introductory talk and that was the first time we had obviously heard each other's voices, or,

well, heard each other voice's in a long, long time. So that ... was that was pretty cool and then ... the ... We did that a couple of times and then, I can't recall if we'd started phoning each other directly at that point or if it was after we met but, anyway, we had then arranged to meet at *location redacted* in *date redacted* ... where we had our first face to face meeting.

OD Was *social worker* there with you?

DH: *Social worker* was there with us.

OD: So, it's ... it's impossible, I think, for someone who hasn't experienced that to understand it. But your expectations of what you think that would be like based on your own experience and things like that and I think one of the trickiest things for me, as someone who hasn't gone through adoption, is that we often have sort of like media representations of adoption as being something very different to what it actually is. And, so, I always think of all the films where people are reunited after years apart and it's always a happy ending and there's very little friction and it's always, you know, clear cut reasons why something happened and I'm just wondering ... that can't be the reality of it and, and what you told me over these six years is that is that, that isn't the reality of it!

DH: Yeah.

OD: But what about when you meet in person what, what, what is that like?

DH: Yeah, when we met in person it was very, it was, you know, little Hollywood in that it was very emotional and, you know, the way *name of social worker* had it set up was that *birth mother's name redacted* was in a

room, myself and my wife were in another room and *social worker* was like: "Right she's here. Are you ready?" And I was like: "Yeah, let's go." And I kinda walked with *social worker* into the room, so it was very much ... like we hugged and held each other for quite a while and cried. So, at that point it was very typical, you know, what you would see in a, in a drama or whatever or a depiction of it ... so that was quite emotional. And then I found it was very ... myself ... or *social worker* kinda sat down and was like: "OK ... so let's ... DH has some questions, I'm sure you have some questions." And we just went through ... so a lot of the stuff she [birth mother] couldn't talk about. She couldn't talk about *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* a lot. She was like "I can't, I can't go into it ... it's just too hurtful, it's too, you know, painful and everything else". So, she was like: "Right now I can't, maybe I will be able to, but right now I can't." And then, she was able to give me the full story as it happened, when it happened and everything else so that was really, that was really interesting to ..., you know, the whole blow by blow. So that's obviously filled in all ... a ton of gaps. So, in terms of like, a significant day in my life: that was a significant day in my life [laughs]. So that was, it was, it was pretty incredible and then, you know, we went ... *Social worker* was like: "Alright, the two of youse of you go, you're on your way, my work is done so." We went for lunch. I think ... I don't know if it was that day or maybe I came up to *location redacted* my own the next day and we spent the day together. And then, I had met her sister and some of my cousins, it was either that day of or the next day. I think it was the day of, because she had told them about me and then we had decided that okay we're gonna go ... myself, my wife we're gonna go to *location in England redacted* for a day or two ... for two days and we were going to meet with her and meet my half sister and her family. So it was a little bit of a whirlwind, and various difference, you know, emotional up and down and everything else and it was pretty full on and then what was really good was that, whenever we were flying out from Belfast to *location in

England*, [we] went to the airport and there was all my extended family, that were there and I got to introduce everybody and it was meeting others cousins and different things, and my uncle, her [birth mother's] brother. And we were sitting there around the table and my wife was nudging my uncle's wife and saying: "Look at their hands! Their hands are exactly the same" [laughs]. And things like that so ... that was fantastic. And then, over in *location in England*, meeting my half sister and her husband and daughter, that was all fantastic and really, really, really emotional. Oh yes! My ... *birth mother's name redacted* had come down to *location in Northern Ireland* as well. So I brought her down ... She wanted to go and see my mother's grave. She met my dad [DH's adoptive father]. Yeah, yeah. So, yeah, no it was incredibly ... busy time.

OD: Like I said I can't imagine ...but you ... it ... I just I think it's incredible to reconnect and especially that you have managed to see all of your ... all this extended family that you maybe didn't even know existed.

DH: Yeah, yeah.

OD: When you ... so you mentioned earlier that your, your birth mother has had a partner? Was he sort of instrumental in either ... in sort of, you not meeting. Was there hesitation ... had she not told ...

DH: No, no, no, no ... so he ... the two of them were engaged before I was born, so they had been going out for a couple of years and had been engaged. They had split up in a ... I don't know how. I don't know the details of the split. If you talked to my half-sister she doesn't see it as a split, but *name of birth mother redacted* sees it as a split. So, he went to *location redacted* to work for some friends, wanted her to come with him and she decided not to. Then she

met my father and went out with him for a small, brief period. And then, that ended and then she went to the *location redacted* for the summer, with some of her friends and they all got sick ... working in a hotel and they all got sick and they went to the doctor and the doctor was like [addressing each of them in turn]: “You’ve got food poisoning; you've got food poisoning; you're pregnant.” So that's when she found out and then she decided that she was going to go to *location redacted* to meet up with her, her fiancé I guess and all sorts of things were going through her mind. And at one point she said she was going to tell him that I was his, and then she realised that all the dates won't match up or whatever. So, then she just came clean and he was obviously very hurt but supportive and they stayed in *location redacted* and then he went back with her to *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* and then she came out of [there], the two of them went to *location in England* and got married, and had two more kids. He was very ... he’s always said he was always encouraging her to find me one. And I think ... one of the things that she did say was that around that hesitancy the first time, she had mentally prepared herself for me to start looking for her when I was eighteen. So, she felt if he's ever going to look for me it's gonna be when he’s eighteen. So when that didn't happen and the years kinda ticked on, I guess she must have dealt with that as some sort of rejection as well, because she had it built up on her mind that, you know, I was going to come back shortly after I was eighteen . So, that explained the first one. The first rejection. Then when, whenever her partner had passed away, you know, he died ... he had a massive heart attack in the middle of the night, so it was really sudden. And she just couldn’t, you know, emotionally couldn't cope with it so that, kind of, connected all the dots in terms of, you know, the first few years and I totally understood from that perspective.

OD: I ... because I was wondering about that because obviously lots of people have talked about the fact that when you were eighteen everything, kind of,

changes but actually most people I've spoken to ... that turning eighteen isn't the point where they start looking.

DH: No.

OD: I know you're able to ... I mean think about yourself at eighteen as well that's, you know, when you think about it in terms of from the perspective of the birth mother, you know, that's eighteen years they may have been waiting, but when you think about it from the perspective of an eighteen year old ... how on earth would anyone be ready at eighteen to go through that or even have the, kind of, knowledge to, to start looking.

DH: Yeah. And at eighteen, at eighteen I was ... at eighteen I was in *location redacted*, I was at *name of university redacted* and I knew her address and I knew her name and like there was always, you know, anytime I made a had a one too many it was like, you know, maybe I should just go and knock on the door but I knew, was like: "No, Jesus don't do that!" You know, because ... so ...

OD: But what stopped you from doing that? Just out of curiosity was it, was it your own not being ready or was it not wanting her to feel pressured?

DH: Not wanting to ... I knew that if I did that ... I knew if I did that, knocking on somebody's door would turn their world upside down. So, it wasn't ... it didn't ... it couldn't be just about me and what my needs. So, in terms of ... like I'm looking at myself as an eighteen-year-old: I was incredibly immature. And, you know, for me to even think that way I'm fairly impressed looking back that I did have that level of maturity as well because I certainly wasn't mature, you know, as an eighteen-year-old, you know?

OD: I don't think most eighteen-year-olds are. I wasn't.

DH: Oh, especially going to university and you're away from home for the first time!

OD: Well, that's what's so interesting ... this is, this is yet again one of those things that as an outsider it's interesting to try and comprehend sometimes is, is what stops people from doing that? Like, I can completely understand why you wouldn't do that but it, but it always feels like, like what *physically* stops you and what *emotionally* stops you are two very different things.

DH: Yeah.

OD: And, you know, some people, some people probably would do that and then I think *name of social worker redacted* is exactly right, you know, anything that is a way to blow up a relationship before it's

DH: Yeah. Yeah and it's something like, I mean, now that we're talking about it, I know over the years people have said, you know, ... cause it was always, it was always on my mind in my twenties. It was always on my mind. And then there was various different things happened, and my adoptive mother passed away when I was twenty- five, and at university and, and things like that. So there, you know, there was other things that were happening in my life and I think ... I remember, you know, somebody told me: "You'll know when you're ready and don't do it till you're ready."

And I was like "How will I know when I'm ready?"

And he says, "Well, do you feel ready now?"

"No."

And he says, “Well, there you go.” [DH laughs] “You’re not ready.”

So ... and it was, you know, it was, I was always ... I always had a ... I always had a really good group of close friends, still to this day that, you know. I'm still in contact and they were always incredibly supportive and we were always supportive of each other and I think that that's ... that was key in me determining when I was ready for something or not and, you know, that guidance that I got from friends.

OD: That's lovely. That's really lovely and I think that that question that your friend asked you, you know, are you ... instead of saying like, how will I know when I'm ready? Just asking yourself: are you ready? So just, just, kind of, like more long term, did you maintain a relationship with your birth mother? Do you still see them or ...?

DH: So that that's, that's kind of, where it got little, a little tricky. We had a ... right out of the gate there was like ... we were phoning each other every week. It was like a brand new relationship, and writing letters and everything else. *Name of birth mother redacted* came over to *overseas location*; it was either that year or the following year and stayed with me and my wife for a week ... and that was fantastic, the first three, first three or four days and then we had went out for lunch one time, just me and her, and I had started asking more about my birth father. And she was like: “I, I don't really, I don't really want to go into it and I don't really ... I know if you're ... I'm not interested in meeting him.” And I was like: “Well I don't expect that you would be interested in meeting him, and that's not what I'm asking...”

OD: Yeah.

DH: “...But I feel that I would like to find him.”

She goes “OK well I'm ... I'm not ... I'm not going to have anything to do with that.”

And I was like “But, you know, why would you not help me?”

And she was like “I don't want anything to do with it”.

And we'd a little bit of a falling out and then for the rest of the week she kinda huffed with me for the next few days and like it was really, really weird because the three of us were in this like, two-bedroom apartment together and she was huffing. And myself and my wife were going: “What do we do here?” So, that was hard, and I think she went back and then there, you know, we still had that relationship going back and forth and she explained: “You know, you've got your own family in *location in Northern Ireland redacted*, then there's us and then if you meet your birth father that's gonna be another family. So, every time you come back from *overseas location* you're gonna be here, there ... you know, you're not going to spending anytime with us.”

And I was like; “Like that's *my* problem to solve, it's not your problem.”

So that was fine ... and the relationship was a little ... it was, it wasn't too bad. It was still good. We were able to maintain it. After my first boy was born, we went over to Ireland for the christening and she was there, she came over from England for the christening as well. I have a lovely photograph of all my family and, and *name of birth mother redacted* in the middle of us. You know, in the church after, after the christening and my uncle actually baptised my son, which was pretty nice. So that was good. He's a priest by the way so, just in case... [laughs] ... he's not like a plumber that decided to give it a go! So that was, that was great and then I think ... she found it ...she ... so that ... there was a whole thing of who she talked to me about. She talked to me about ... with her close family, but not all of her family ... like there was a sister that she didn't, she didn't tell her at all but one sister she did and her brother she did. So it was, kind of, like I'm ... because he had fallen out with that sister, so she wasn't talking to that sister, so she was like ... I was like: “Surely this is something that you can

talk about and this is a way to reconcile with her as well?” And she’s like: “No, no.” And then her friends in *location in England redacted*, she didn't talk to me about. And then, and then I realised that she wasn't even ... like when she was talking about her grandkids she was talking about my sister's kids but she wasn't talking about my boys. So that was hard, that was really, really hard and that hurt my wife a lot. She kept [saying], you know: “Denying you is one thing but she can't deny them ... that's ... they're, they're mine ... you know, she can't.” So that, that was a little bit of friction. Then, when was it? So, my two boys would have been born so it was probably *dates redacted*, my half-brother got married. He had them move to, to the *overseas location* [and] he decided to get married. So, all the family were coming over. *Name of birth mother redacted* was coming over, my half sister and her family and everything else and I actually officiated the wedding, and not because I'm a priest or anything, I just thought I'd give it a go! [Laughs] So I had officiated the wedding, which is pretty cool but then after that it kinda ... our relationship kinda drifted apart and it was really around that she hadn't, you know, haven't fully shared with her friends that she had this son and that he had this wife, and they had these two boys and things like that. So, it kinda, it kinda drifted. I had a closer relationship then with my sister and my brother and would be in contact with them quite a lot, and they came over to visit here in *location redacted* and spend time with us and yeah, it kinda got a little, kinda got a little strange and then, you know. Birthday cards start ... stop coming, Christmas cards stopped coming, and I would still be in contact occasionally with my sister and my brother, and then it got to the point where my sister told me “she’s starting to show signs of dementia.” And that's, that's where she's [birth mother] at now. Like she’s moved ... down closer to my sister, I think they live near *location in England redacted*. And then recently now she’s living with my sister, done some renovations to be able to get her in there. So, in terms of where she's at,

our relationship is at? It's nearly brand new again, because like when I've been talking to her on Skype she's like, [my sister is] like:

“This is DH.”

“Oh, hello DH”!’

“DH is your son.”

“Oh is he?”

And, you know, chatting away. And then on my birthday this year she gave my sister a birthday card and wished her a happy birthday, so she knew it was somebody's birthday even though it wasn't my sister's. So, there's that and she ... my sister, we had a call, a video call recently and it's the first time I've talked to her in maybe two years, and then my sister had ... I'd sent her all the records I had and my sister and sat with her [DH's birth mother] and went through it and she was totally ... she was like “How could I do that? ... Why does he not hate me? Why did I do ...?” And it was just like there's no ... like she couldn't comprehend why she would give her child up for adoption and it was, was awful to hear that and it was awful to hear ... But, again that, that torment is gone in a second because two minutes later she won't remember the conversation. But just for her to go through that was hard to hear so ... yeah ... that's, that's ... our relationship kind of fizzled out so ...

OD: I'm really sorry about the ... dementia is such a cruel...

DH: Yeah.

OD. Anyway but to have, to have that relationship sort of stalled by that is awful, I'm so sorry.

DH: Yeah, yeah.

OD: But what your mum had said about you “how could I have done that?” and stuff? Sounds ... and you said that she would never talk to you about *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* and the experience.

DH: Yeah.

OD... yeah it sounds ... I'm just wondering what, what kind of experience she had that that was, kind of, off limits, back came back and resurface during ...

DH: Yeah. Well, it was funny because once my sister told me that she had, you know, her dementia was getting worse cause I had said, I don't know when I reached out, but I was like: ‘Would *name of birth mother redacted* want to talk?’ And she was like: “No. You're not going to get anything out of her.” And I was like well with dementia... because I could remember my [adoptive] father had died of dementia couple years ago and it was the same with him that, you know, short term stuff's gone but then he would reminisce about stuff from ... So, I was like well maybe all of this will come spilling out but no, I think it's, it's, it's put in a little box and very deep, deep down inside.

OD: I mean from my limited experience doing these interviews speaking with ... I've spoken with what ... fifty, fifty-five women?

DH: Wow.

OD: All of those ... I mean that don't quote me on these numbers ... but those ... those memories are locked away.

DH: Yeah, yeah.

OD: In almost everyone I've spoken to and sometimes they come out through therapy, sometimes they come out through friendship, sometimes it come out in these birth mother groups, you know, where you're surrounded with people who solely understand, you know. Sometimes they don't come out until sixties, seventies, eighties, you know.

DH: Or don't come out at all.

OD: Or don't come out at all. And there are lots of women that I have never ... you know, have no interest in speaking to me and that is absolutely fair enough. They are not talking about this to anyone. I suppose it's, it's ... what comes up more than ever is that, you know ... which is often incomprehensible to someone my age because it's not the case now, but the shame of what happened to them at that age and that experience. It just it never goes away so, you know, feeling ashamed of getting pregnant outside of marriage is so all engrossing that that never ever goes so ... and that's heart breaking because it's, it's, it's not something that I've ever, ever thought of as being particularly bad thing or anything.

DH: Yeah.

OD: That's what we're learning in this project is how, how, how much that can endure.

DH: Yeah, yeah.

OD: And it breaks my heart that that your mother maybe still feels that or ...

DH: Yeah, yeah, and I think that, you know, in terms of *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* and everything else, if they have been put up in a five star hotel and treated like queens and then their babies taken away, the trauma would have been incredible and lifelong anyway so, you know, to add on what potentially could have happened in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* and how they were treated and everything else is just like compounding the, the pain, you know? It's ... that's ... and I know when I read the report² it was just heart breaking to think that she had went through that and then there was, you know, there's, there's girls that were in there exactly the same time as *name of birth mother redacted* and hearing first hand from them is just like 'Oh my God'. No, it's like ... and I know it's the tip of the iceberg, I know that they're not revealing everything and I know that they shouldn't have to reveal anything, everything but it's like ...

OD: what's there all the time is this feeling of guilt and shame.

DH: Yeah.

OD: And being kept in the dark about, about birth, about sex, about what was going to happen with an adoption, you know, and I [inaudible] how ... I wish that she had had some, kind of, help, you know, just like all these ...

DH: I know, I know.

OD: But then also I'm, you know, it it's amazing to hear your side of things as well because I think often there's this idea that adoption just stops everything, you know. It makes everything better, you know, like yeah "You did this

² A reference to the report published in January 2021 on Mother and baby homes and Magdalene laundries in Northern Ireland (accessible at [Research Report on Mother and Baby Homes and Magdalene Laundries in Northern Ireland | Department of Health \(health-ni.gov.uk\)](https://www.health-ni.gov.uk/research-reports/mother-and-baby-homes-and-magdalene-laundries-in-northern-ireland))

shameful thing but we're going ... we're going to sort out and everything's going to be fine". But adoption is, is never just an event it's...

DH: Yeah.

OD : ...a life.

DH: Yeah and I think it, that that's something that you need, you know, growing up I always heard: "Oh aren't you so lucky, aren't you so lucky, aren't your parents wonderful to have adopted three ... three kids?" And "Aren't you ...' And I was like "What? What do you mean so lucky?" And you were just, kind of, brainwashed into that ...thinking that and like here, I remembered I had posted the truth and recovery Facebook post they had put up and I mentioned my interview³ and I put it up on ... I just shared the link on Facebook and I'd got a lot of my friends and family responding and reaching out to me directly and then my cousin was like: "Oh I'm so, so sad. I always thought that, you know, Uncle *redacted* and Aunty *redacted* you know, loved you and they were great parents and I'm sorry to hear this." And I was like "What the fuck?" I said: "Yes, they did love me. Yes, they, they were good parents, but that has nothing to do with what it ... everything else?" So, then I reached out to her separately. Just a direct message and I was like "What part of the interview inferred that they ... that I felt they didn't love me or they weren't good parents?"

And she was like "Oh no, no. I, I found it hard to listen to the interview, I was too nervous. It was just this all the comments and everybody offering you support so I just thought that you ..."

I was like "No, no, no, no don't, don't ..."

³ A media interview involving DH.

So yeah, that whole, that whole inference that, you know, you've suddenly won the lottery and that, you know, you're growing up in this great place and everything else, it's so garbage. Who cares? Who cares where you grew up? If you're not with you're family then who gives a shit? Who gives a shit if I get, you know, if I get a brand new pair of football boots for Christmas when I was seven as opposed to not getting a pair ... you know, getting a bow and arrow when I was seven. You know what I mean? That's all nonsense.

OD: And again your adoptive parents are another, kind of, aspect of adoption proving that it's not ...it's never just ... I think that's, that's what that's what frustrates me the most about these stories is this idea that adoption will make everything better and it doesn't mean ... you know ... I've interviewed people who have had wonderful lives as adoptees or as adopted and that's ... but like you said that's irrelevant. It doesn't take away from this event that happens that then has ramifications and to avoid those ramifications or to pretend that they don't exist is really unfair on you. It's unfair on everyone involved and you shouldn't have to be worried about offending people.

DH: Yeah, yeah. And I did have a wonderful upbringing and I did have a wonderful childhood and I did have a wonderful life, but I didn't know what I was missing because I never had it so, you know, it's, it's ... you know. I'm pretty close with my brother and my sister and obviously we have no blood connection whatsoever, but we all, we all had a commonality in that we all came from *the same Good Shepherd mother and baby home*. We're all adopted.

OD: They all came from *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*?

DH: They all came from *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*, yeah.

OD: Wow! That's interesting, wow.

DH: And I know that there's a connection ... So, on my [adoptive] mother's side of the family as I said my ... uncle baptised my son. On my mother's side of the family she has [a number of sisters who became nuns] my cousin that had reached out ... that had posted a comment, was a nun and then left. So ... yeah ... the Catholic Church reigns large on that side of the family. So, I think there was actually ... my [adoptive] mum had ...had contacted ... there various in the old nun telegraph system or whatever it was that, that's how the contact was made and everything else but...

OD: And obviously, you know, with that connection you'd have been like considered an ideal candidate?

DH: Yeah exactly. Yeah, yeah, yeah.

OD: Wow! That's so interesting. I've never heard multiple, multiple family members before that's ... were you all similar ages or was it big gaps?

DH: No! Big gaps, so my, my older brother is three years older than me, he was born in *date redacted* and then my sister is too two and a half years younger so it was, kind of, like a three year ... get them out of nappies, get them up walking; alright let's get another one. Buh-buh-bom [laughs while making sound of a drum]!

OD: So interesting! It's hard ... it's really hard ... it's really hard because there's no, there's no common thread running...

DH: There's not.

OD: We get all these stories from all these different places and there's similar memories and there's similar things, but the circumstances are always so interesting and different and ...

DH: The impact, the impact on the individual is different like my brother and my sister and me have very different outlook on this. They all went through the journey that I went through and all had different end results but my brother wouldn't be prepared or wouldn't be able, not prepared, wouldn't be able to do what I'm doing because he was like: "I just get", he says "it's not even hungry, it's a primal rage that I feel as soon as I start going down that down that road to think about it." My sister wouldn't be in a position to do it either, you know, wouldn't have the strength to do it. It's not something that, you know, she couldn't come out and talk like this so in terms of my participation I'm not just doing it for me, I'm not just doing it for me and *name of birth mother redacted*, I'm doing for my brother and my sister and for everybody else that can't. You know and it's ... I'm sitting on these Zoom calls, you know, you hear people saying: "There's 10,000 women went through these, which means there's 10,000 children. Why are we only three hundred in this [victims' and survivors' group]?" And I'm like ... because first of all, there's 10,000 over a period of years so if you break that down into those that are still alive, now you got to see those that are aware of it, then another subset of those that are able to do it and it's, it's that much out of everybody ... So, it's, it's ... you're really only going to get a small sample set out of the total amount because people, as you said, birth mothers aren't able. Children, whether or they know or not, don't want to do it.

OD: I also think researchers sometimes have a tendency to think like, you know, like "Well why wouldn't people want to talk to me? I'm trying to do

something.” [But] of course they don't want to talk to you! Of course someone doesn't, you know, if people aren't interested in talking to me and Sean that is so understandable.

DH: It's not that they don't want to talk to *you*. They just don't want to talk, because they can't...

OD: Well, so a lot of research that I've done and that Sean's done over this project and a couple of other projects that I've done, they often deal with subjects that are like difficult, like trauma, things that generate trauma and things like that and I think what people tend to forget when researching those things is that they're not subject material, it's people's lives and then that's really crucial. So, choosing to research those areas means that you have to be responsible to people's lives and expectations and the fact that like I said, before this isn't just tell me about your adoption. This is tell me about everything that's happened in your life because of this adoption. What's the ongoing effect? And what's the generational effect and, you know, if you are not able to do that ... that says nothing about your experience or that you're not brave or anything like that, it's that, that's your life. Why should you share that unless you want to? And so what you, you said about, kind of, those people missing from that record and on how few people came forward and things like that, to me that's, that's, that's so understandable. Of course, it's a small sample, that's what you're going to get. For every person we speak to there are tens of people who are still living with all of this shame. And I suppose that's why Sean and I wanted to do this website alongside the Report because what, what I was hoping was that if people didn't feel able to tell their story out loud, hearing someone else tell a version of that story might be something that can mitigate some of that shame that people are still living with because it's so hard. There are women who were seventeen, eighteen still feeling that shame in their seventies and their eighties.

DH: I know, I know. And I think that, you know, when I did the *media interview* that was my thought. What was very much in my forefront, is that if this helps one other person come forward to get help brilliant, you know? So, I mean that's, that's really it as well. And, you know, I'm, I'm blessed that I'm able to do it. I'm blessed that I'm able to talk about it and everything else. Now that doesn't mean that it doesn't have an impact on me, but it just means that I'm in a position that I can deal with it.

OD: But you ... you ... this is quite a remarkable interview in terms of your ability to kind of, self-reflect and talk about your ... not only your physical experience but sort of the emotional journey that it was as well and I think that will help a lot of people too. And there's been a few people I've spoken to recently where I've thought, this is clearly very difficult but what you've done is going to be so beneficial to other people. Just based on the amount of testimony that I've heard and what it is that people are looking for out of this and a lot of it is: "Was I alone?" Was this something ... I went through this alone? So, was I the only one who went through this?" And the only way to tackle that is, is to remind people that not only were they not alone, that this was a catastrophically large proportion of the population of Northern Ireland that went through this but that everyone was made to feel alone and terrible.

DB: Yeah.

OD: So, Sean and I were just hoping that that the website will, like I said, give, give ... at least will help people hear their words through someone else's experience. Maybe, maybe they went to a different home, maybe they had a different experience, maybe they had a different, sort of, unification experience. Like maybe they met their birth parents but that didn't go well. You know, all of

these things, but there'll be these small truths running through them and they'll be like that 'I remember that' or 'I remember that aspect' you know? Even, even some of the ... you'll have seen in the Report, you know. There's, there's lots of references to cleaning stairs, that came up in almost every testimony we listen to. It's such a tiny thing that you might not pick up on because people sometimes listen to these stories and perhaps expect them to be, you know, just like violence constantly or all these things and actually what these stories say more than ever is these small humiliations or these small experiences that have stuck with them their entire lives. But you've got sixty women saying the same thing. "I remember these stairs" and how it felt to clean them when they were nine months pregnant, you know, all of this. Actually, I think just being able to hear that and maybe someone will say "Oh my story really wasn't that bad" and then to hear someone talking about the stairs that they also cleaned maybe will make them realise that they don't have to have the worst story in the world to not still feel that shame and humiliation.

DH: Yeah.

OD: I have kept you for an hour and I'm really sorry about that.

DH: Oh, no problem.

OD: But I felt that I wanted to hear some of your reflections towards the end as well because I thought they were really valuable. I ... do you have anything else that you want to say now that was on this record and this ... is there anything that you feel we haven't covered or ...?

DH: I, I think for, for me they the impact that it's had on me as a person has been significant. You know, I've dealt with mental health issues, diagnosed

probably for ten years but certainly twenty-thirty years, thirty years easily, maybe, maybe even longer. Anxiety issues when I was a child. Insecurity issues. Abandonment issues as a child, you know, and it's all ... it's only really now, looking back or in the past ten years looking back then, you know, after having counselling and other things is that, you know, you can realise that your feelings ... the way you are and the things that you go through are not your fault and not of your making. And that's, that's been for me, I think that, that's, that was hard to arrive at that point, point ... to realise, you know, I didn't do this to me, somebody else did this to me.

OD: That phrase you used is coming up a lot and that, kind of, I ... women getting to the point ... so I probably spoke to women and Sean predominantly spoke to men

DH: Yeah.

OD: So, I can only really speak about the women that I interviewed, the majority of whom were birth mothers but they had that exact same realisation. You know, "I spent my entire life blaming myself for something ... how could I have let someone go? How could I have not kept them? I should have done more." But when they tell me their stories, I'm saying what possible choice did you have? You were given no choice; this wasn't your fault. But that doesn't mean that the adopted children aren't also feeling the exact same way

DH: Yeah.

OD: ...with and, and what, what it comes down to is blame has been placed perhaps on the wrong parties for so long and of course, of course, again it comes down to that, you know, [being told] "oh weren't you're lucky?" you

know. Well that makes it worse because if you feeling all these things and everyone's telling you you're lucky, of course, of course you're gonna be confused and frustrated and then develop all these concepts ... it ... I ... without understanding I empathise I suppose.

DH: Yeah.

OD: And the long term thing is, it's heart breaking. But I'm, I'm really happy to hear that you have wonderful kids and it sounds like an incredible wife who's kind of, been there and that, that side of things is one of the most magical parts of these interviews is that often the people involved either from a birth mother perspective or an adopted child perspective tend to go on and have these incredible families and it's, it's lovely to see.

DH: Yeah, yeah.

OD: So yeah, I'm glad about that. So, if you're happy then maybe we will stop there? Or is there..

DH: Sure, yep that's fine.

[INTERVIEW ENDS]